

STANDING ORDER

a short film

Blue Sheep Films

working draft v1.1

INT. ARTHUR'S FLAT - KITCHEN - FRIDAY MORNING

A kettle that predates the internet. A radio doing the weather. ARTHUR (late 70s) lays out one cup, one saucer, one spoon, with the precision of a man who has stopped noticing he does it.

The DOORBELL.

He checks the wall clock – 9:40 – and nods, unsurprised.

INT. ARTHUR'S FLAT - HALLWAY - CONTINUOUS

He opens the door to a DELIVERY KID (20s) holding flowers. Freesias, wrapped in paper.

DELIVERY KID
Friday, Mr. Bram.

ARTHUR
Friday.

He takes them. Doesn't tip – waves the kid off before the thought can finish forming.

ARTHUR (CONT'D)
Tell Marco the last lot drooped by Tuesday.

DELIVERY KID
He says freesias do that and you say it every week.

ARTHUR
And one week I'll be right.

INT. ARTHUR'S FLAT - KITCHEN - CONTINUOUS

The freesias go into a green glass vase that has held flowers every week for a very long time. Tucked in the paper, a small printed card. He doesn't read it. He knows what it says.

We read it: LOVE, E.

He touches the card once, the way you touch a banister. Then: tea.

MAIN TITLE: STANDING ORDER

INT. ARTHUR'S FLAT - HALLWAY - DAY

Post rattles through the slot. Bills, a flyer – and one envelope with a bank's logo. Blue. Official.

Arthur opens it standing up, glasses on his forehead, then lowered.

INSERT - LETTER

RE: ACCOUNT REVIEW — DORMANT PARTY. Our records indicate the account holder is deceased. In line with policy, all recurring payments and scheduled instructions on this account will be terminated in 30 days.

BACK TO SCENE. Arthur reads it twice. Looks down the hall at the kitchen, at the green vase just visible through the door, freesias leaning.

ARTHUR
Six years it takes you.

INT. BANK BRANCH - DAY

A branch that used to have people in it. Now: pods, screens, one human — CLERK (20s), lanyard, kind face, hands tied in forty separate procedural knots.

Arthur sits across from her with the letter flattened on the desk like evidence.

CLERK
So the account belongs to —
(reading)
— Edith Bram.

ARTHUR
My wife.

CLERK
And she passed —

ARTHUR
Six years in March.

CLERK
(softening)
I'm sorry.

ARTHUR
The account sends things. Small things. I'd like it left alone.

She types. Reads. Types. Whatever is on her screen makes her sit back slightly.

CLERK
There are... quite a few scheduled instructions on this account.

ARTHUR
The flowers. Fridays.

CLERK
Mr. Bram, there are twenty-three
active instructions.

Arthur blinks. Recalculates something private.

ARTHUR
Twenty-three.

CLERK
I can't disclose the details.
You're not a named party on this
account.

ARTHUR
I was married to the named party
for forty-one years.

CLERK
(genuinely wretched
about it)
I know. I believe you. But the
system needs –
(beat)
– it needs her to confirm.

The sentence sits between them in all its glory.

ARTHUR
You need my dead wife's permission
to tell me what she's doing.

CLERK
...Yes.

ARTHUR
(standing, hat on)
She'd have loved that. She kept a
scrapbook of this sort of thing.

INT. ARTHUR'S FLAT - KITCHEN - DAY

Arthur on the landline, on hold. The hold music is a
synthesizer being optimistic. He holds the receiver a foot
from his ear and drinks his tea.

AUTOMATED VOICE (V.O.)
Your call is important to us. You
are number... fourteen... in the
queue.

He does the crossword. Fills in three answers.

AUTOMATED VOICE (V.O.)
Your call is important to us. You
are number... fourteen... in the
queue.

ARTHUR
(to the receiver, mild)
You said that.

INT. BARBER SHOP - DAY

A two-chair shop. SAM the barber (60s) trims what remains of Arthur's hair. Comfortable silence of long acquaintance.

Arthur goes for his wallet. Sam waves it off.

SAM
Taken care of, Art.

ARTHUR
(still, in the mirror)
Taken care of how?

SAM
How it's always taken care of.
Comes through every eight weeks,
regular as church.
(off Arthur's face)
...You knew that. You knew that,
didn't you?

Arthur looks at himself in the mirror. Fresh-cut. Six years of haircuts he thought he'd been forgetting to pay for and nobody minded.

ARTHUR
The drooping freesias. The
crossword magazine. The cake on my
birthday from Petra's with the
lemon thing on it -

SAM
The lemon glaze.

ARTHUR
I never ordered that cake, Sam.

SAM
Well somebody bloody does. Same
order as always, Petra says.

Arthur takes off the cape himself. Something has assembled itself behind his eyes and it is enormous.

INT. ARTHUR'S FLAT - BEDROOM - NIGHT

The wardrobe. Her side, still her side. Arthur takes down a shoebox – papers, photos, a wedding ring on a ribbon.

He finds a notebook. Edie's handwriting: lists. Birthdays, sizes, the names of neighbours' children, WHAT ARTHUR FORGETS in block letters at the top of one page, underlined twice.

Under it, an old bank slip. A meeting confirmation – "scheduled instructions setup, E. Bram" – dated four months before the date Arthur will not say out loud.

She knew she was going. She spent her last spring in a bank branch, scheduling.

Arthur sits on the bed, on her side, holding the slip.

ARTHUR
You daft, magnificent woman.

INT. BANK BRANCH - DAY

Arthur back at the desk. The Clerk looks miserable before he even sits.

CLERK
The review's automatic, Mr. Bram. I escalated it. It came back –
(reading, hating it)
– "policy-compliant." The instructions terminate Friday. I'm so sorry. I did try.

ARTHUR
Can I pay for them myself? Take them over. Same flowers, same barber, same cake.

CLERK
You could set up your own. But the details of hers are sealed, so you would be – guessing.
(beat)
There's one thing I can tell you. It's allowed because it names you.

ARTHUR
Go on.

CLERK

Instruction twenty-three is a letter. Held by the branch. Release condition -

(reading)

- "upon termination of the foregoing, deliver to my husband."

(looks up)

She knew they'd cancel her, Mr. Bram. She wrote for it.

Arthur says nothing. His hat is in his hands.

CLERK (CONT'D)

I'm Ruth, by the way. If you want the complaint form.

ARTHUR

No complaint, Ruth. You were the only part of this with a pulse.

(standing)

Fridays I'm at fourteen Elm. My wife would want somebody to see the wrong flowers.

INT. ARTHUR'S FLAT - KITCHEN - FRIDAY MORNING

9:40. The doorbell does not ring.

Arthur stands in the kitchen with one cup, one saucer, one spoon. The green vase, empty, washed, upside down on the rack. The wall clock is very loud.

The LETTERBOX rattles. One envelope. Her handwriting.

He sits down before he opens it. Smooths it flat.

INSERT - LETTER, EDIE'S HAND

Arthur. If this reached you, the bank has finally noticed I'm gone. I guessed five years - took them six, so you owe me a pound.

The flowers stop now. That's on purpose, love. Freesias droop by Tuesday anyway. This Friday you'll go to Marco's and choose your own, and they'll be the wrong ones, and that's the point. Wrong flowers you picked beat right flowers I scheduled.

Tip Marco. He's been undercharging you six years because I asked him to.

You were never any good at being looked after from a distance. Come closer. Look after something yourself.

All my love, all of it, E.

BACK TO SCENE. Arthur at the table. The radio does the weather. He lets it finish. Then he laughs – once, wet, enormous – and wipes his eyes with the heel of his hand.

ARTHUR
A pound. Fine.

EXT. FLOWER MARKET - FRIDAY - LATER

Colour everywhere. Arthur moves down the stalls like a man in a foreign country. MARCO (50s) watches him approach with the wariness of six years of drooping-freesia complaints.

MARCO
Mr. Bram. Friday order's – off, I
heard. I'm sorry –

ARTHUR
I'll choose my own.

Marco blinks. Recovers. Gestures at the stall: all of it.

Arthur looks. Truly does not know what he's doing. Picks up something orange, something blue, a fistful of something white. It is, objectively, a terrible bouquet.

MARCO
...Interesting direction.

ARTHUR
They're the wrong ones.

MARCO
They're very much the wrong ones.

ARTHUR
(paying – adding a note,
folding Marco's hand
around it)
Good. And that's six years of
tips. There's a pound in there
that's not for you.

INT. ARTHUR'S FLAT - KITCHEN - DAY

The terrible bouquet in the green vase. It clashes with everything. It's perfect.

Arthur at the table – with paperwork. His own bank's forms. Reading glasses. He fills in a standing instruction in slow, careful capitals.

We see only fragments: PETRA'S BAKERY... EVERY YEAR ON THE 12TH... and on the recipient line, a name we don't know – and then, at the bottom, under SPECIAL CONDITIONS, in his steady hand:

CONTINUE AFTER MY DEATH. DO NOT NOTIFY THE RECIPIENT WHO SENT IT. THEY'LL WORK IT OUT.

He signs. Checks the wall clock. Puts the kettle on – and takes down a second cup.

The doorbell rings.

CUT TO BLACK.

THE END